

Our story begins in a valley nestled between two mountains. In a small but bustling village by the name of Greenhaven. Home to those who some say could be considered nature incarnate... druids. Greenhaven was safely tucked away from the world and those who inhabit it, which was just fine for its nature loving inhabitants. Among these inhabitants is the true protagonist of this story, with a name forgotten to time, we shall refer to him as Gramps.

At this point in time, our protagonist is surely not up to such a name, at the ripe age of but thirty. Up until this point in his life, things had been going swimmingly. Studiously learning everything he could in the village's library, from books of Arcana to mundane books about survival. Devouring knowledge with but one purpose in mind, to pass it on to the next generation. Indeed, our protagonist's calling in life was to teach. To guide the young seedlings until they blossomed into the outstanding beings he knew they would become. Yes, things were

truly going swimmingly... until they weren't.

It all began the morning after Gramps celebrated his thirtieth birthday. Awakening to... something. Assuming it was just the grogginess of another early morning following a late night of studying, Gramps proceeded with his day as normal. Every morning began with his favorite tea, simple pine needs steeped in freshly boiled spring water. "The drink of Mother Nature, surely." he would always say as he sipped while reviewing that which he had studied the night before. An old but helpful habit in retaining all that he had learned. Progressing with his day as usual, he began to notice something odd, whisper here, a shadow there. It came to a boiling point when he was sure someone had yelled his name just outside his study. "Who's there!?" Gramps yelled, something of a rarity for him. He had always prided himself on his calm nature, something that was to serve him well in educating the bright but rowdy youths of the village. Becoming slightly unsettled with his current condition, he went to that which had always pointed him in the

right direction. Books. Scouring through books ranging from psychedelic episodes to curses of old, nothing he found seemed to truly match up until he laid eyes on it. A dusty book with just a bit of color shining through. He felt compelled to read it immediately. "The answers lie within it! Definitely!" he shouted as he grabbed it. Blowing away the dust revealed a book bound in leather that had been dyed amethyst. The writing on it stange, yet seemingly familiar. "This... no." he muttered, eyes slightly wide upon recognizing the language.

Just as clouds waft leisurely in the sky, so too does time pass. It had been just over fifteen years since our protagonist's relaxed yet fulfilling life changed. Fifteen years since he came upon the book within which he knew held his answers. Fifteen years since... he said goodbye to his home of thirty years, to his books that had accompanied him, to the children of the village he wished to help guide, to all his dreams and aspirations. What he had found within the book that day left him with no choice. He wouldn't

endanger all that he held dear for his own selfish desires. So out of the village he went, to seek a solution to an ever-growing problem. As the years went by, that which followed him grew worse. The shadows became full-blown figures, the whispers complete conversations. It truly dealt a blow when he began seeing those he left behind in his village, almost as if whatever was following him wished him to go back so that it may follow them as well. Never staying in a singular place for long, he had grown quite used to being alone. Though, he was never truly alone, not with them always talking to him, chattering, whispering, mumbling. Peace. That was what he had come to desire. Whilst traveling, he had noticed something. The animals. The animals never seemed quite as affected by being around him as the more sentient creatures did. When around them and nature, he had come to realize the figures weren't as prominent, the voices not as loud. With this in mind, and his sanity hanging by a thread from years of being followed, he came to a decision. Seclusion. When traveling, he had seen many large forests, surely home to

a plethora of animals and beasts of wonder, but he knew his destination almost immediately. A small, easily overlooked grouping of trees. Slightly bigger than a grove, but not quite a forest. Within were many mundane animals, hares, foxes, deer, and even a family of bears. The only other inhabitants being an odd group of goblins, just three in number but all well passed their prime. Strangely enough, they seemed completely neutral to his arrival, almost as if seeing a companion in self isolation. His reasoning for choosing here? The center. There lied a lake that seemed to exude serenity. Yes, this would be his home now...

For 130 years, a hollowed out tree near a lake within a blooming forest had been his home. During this time, the knowledge he had learned in his youth served him well. His magic reserves, once considered lofty within the druid society, had dwindled. Not due to age, but choice, the forest now surrounding him proof of this. For sheltering him, he decided to pay it back, rent you could say. The payment? His magic. A little

bit every day, over the span of 130 years, and you have quite the spectacular forest now.

His love for knowledge never dwindled during this time, and though he had no books to read, he did have a language to learn. The goblins had died years ago, but not before becoming his teacher. They talked to him regularly, usually at his expense, not expecting the man to understand them. How they underestimated his sharp mind and ability to learn.

After the goblins had passed, his only companions were the creatures of the forest. His ability to understand and appease animals had become almost second nature to him. They had come to look up to him, for his knowledge and wisdom. The kind old man, hidden behind a grizzled and haunted face. Always ready to offer his advice for the adversities they had encountered. Gramps. That was what they had taken to affectionately calling him. His real name lost with the years.

The years of being followed and his continuous expenditure of magic had aged him beyond his years. This would be his resting place, he was sure of it, and that was fine. This forest had become more than a home, it was almost as if the forest were he, and he the forest. It would live on in his place, long after he had passed. This he was sure of, just as he had been of his calling all those years ago. Closing his eyes to rest after another days expenditure of magic to the forest, a breeze began to blow. A gentle gust of wind at first, that began picking up speed quickly, until soon the entire forest was experiencing a squall of unusual magnitude. Standing with a slight start, he began to feel something. Similar to what he had felt all those years ago to a certain book, but this time positive in nature. Whatever it was, it was compelling him to leave the forest. The forest he had become so close with, the family of snow hares that burrowed near his home, the pair of foxes that had just given birth to a litter of cubs, and most importantly, the lake that had only grown in serenity since he took up residency

here.

The forest, feeling its other half's hesitation, began to stir. The family of hares all leaving their burrows to look at him, "Gramps! Gramps!" the young leverets called to him. The pair of foxes left their den, young cubs following behind them, eyes barely opened. "Gramps!" the pair of foxes called to him as well. The birds in the trees, the bears in their caves, the deer wandering, they all stopped. Looking in the same direction, "Gramps!". Even without using his cantrip, he knew what they were saying. With wetted eyes, he once more made a decision. "Truly... have I grown hesitant in my old age?" he laughed, a bitter but heartfelt laugh. He went into his residency, taking with him the few items he still had from his youth. His trusty wooden shield, taken well care of over the years even though it served no use any longer. A scimitar that he had rarely used. His backpack, filled with everyday necessities, a tinderbox here, some rope there, and what kind of druid would he be without his focus?



With his items packed, and his heart heavy with the love the forest and its inhabitants have for him, he set off once more. As he walked from the lake, the whispers got louder. As he left the coverage of trees, the figures returned. Looking back one last time at what he had called home for the last century, he saw many eyes looking back at him. "Wait for me..." he whispered. With newfound resolution, he turned back onto his path, heading where the feeling was pulling him towards. Ironically, it was in the same direction the wind blew. "The winds of fate, perhaps?" he thought.